

fabled organizations were banned from competing in a CS:GO tournament, the ESL Pro League Season 15. The stated reason behind this was the country of registration and certain affiliations of these organizations. While it was a major setback for the organizations, as they were set to lose a ton of money, it was an even bigger issue for the players, as they were left without a name to play for. At the time of these events occurring, both these teams were among the top 10 teams in the world. So, you can imagine the plight of the players who had dedicated years to better their skills at the game being suddenly left without an organization that could compete and with a tournament as important as ESL Pro League ahead of them.

Since the ban was on the organizations and not the players, they decided to compete under different 'neutral' names. Gambit took the name of 'Players', while the individuals from Virtus.Pro competed as 'Outsiders'. It wasn't just these two organizations or these two rosters of players who were left in the middle of nowhere. There were others too, who went to sleep as a part of a huge and flourishing team but woke up to the news of not being a part of one anymore or even as refugees in some cases.

Luckily for the former players for Gambit, the days ahead look bright, as their entire roster has been signed recently by Cloud9 bringing them back to the mainstream. For the players of Virtus.Pro though, there is no great news insight. Here we also need to understand the mental bearing that such incidents have on the players. Being stuck in such situations is not an easy task to undertake, especially when so many other things are going down around you at the same time.

Abandonment

While the above-stated examples were from the cases where there was a known reason for everything that happened, there are cases where for the players, it is just a cesspool of

confusion and speculation. This was the case for the FunPlus Phoenix CS:GO roster in March 2020. To explain it all in the simplest of words, while the players of the organization, having travelled across the globe to the United States of America, prepared to take part in a match against another organization in the Flashpoint tournament, all hell broke loose on them.

First, a player was announced to have signed up with a rival organization. Next, their upcoming match was forfeited, and it wasn't long until FunPlus Phoenix announced that they would release all the players from their roster and not be taking further part in the tournament. This



es3tag was a welcome addition for Astralis

Source:
Astralis Counter-Strike via Twitter

literally left all of its players stuck in another country in the middle of a raging pandemic. Sharing his views on the incident was the team's prime player, Casper "cadian" Møller, who, in a post on his Twitter handle after the events unfolded, said that he was "gutted" and this was mistreatment that he had never seen in his life before. So, you can gauge how it must have been for the rest of the players.

There's another case from the world of DOTA 2 this time that would help you even better with understanding how difficult things can get. In 2019, right before the 'The International 9' DOTA 2 tournament, the organization 'Forward

Gaming' ceased its operations, citing its unfavourable financial situation as the cause of this move. While the leaders of the organization came under fire for leaving its players in the middle of nowhere, the players who had already made their way through to the tournament scrambled to rescue their seemingly doomed dreams of competing in the tournament.

It's not just fun and games

While most people may think of this as just some people getting super competitive about some video games, we need to remember that there is a lot at stake for



One of the former Forward Gaming players, Yawar "YawaR" Hassan

Source:
Forward Gaming via Twitter

these eSports athletes. And in most cases, the situation is such that the players can do nothing about it, unlike other sports. Most of the times, it is just one person from the organization that messes up, jeopardizing the futures of the rest of the individuals.

Whenever such things happen, reality hits us hard, and we are shown the other side, which otherwise eludes us, often being overshadowed by the glamour and fanfare that the eSports scene brings to the table. But once in a while, it is important to look at the dark side of things too. Just to gain some perspective, if nothing else. *